Addis Ababa University

Student Handbook

Official Guide for Students

Prepared For: Research and Documentation Purpose

Date: March 2026

1. Introduction

1.1 Welcome to Addis Ababa University

Addis Ababa University (AAU) is the premier higher education institution in Ethiopia and one of the foremost universities in Africa. As stated in the official Student Handbook, the university's motto is “Seek wisdom, elevate your intellect and serve humanity”. This guide is designed to help students make informed decisions leading to successful and timely completion of their academic programs.

1.2 Purpose of This Handbook

The Student Handbook serves as an official guide containing essential information about the university's structure, policies, procedures, and services. A sincere and scrupulous effort has been made towards completeness, correctness, and relevance of the information in this publication. If there are any errors or omissions in the information presented, students are encouraged to bring them to the university's attention so that future versions will be improved.

1.3 Interpretation and Authority

If there is a dispute in interpretation of the information contained in this Handbook, the Academic Vice President shall provide interpretation. Where the information is in disagreement with the University Senate Legislation, the Legislation shall take precedence.

1.4 Core Values of the University

Addis Ababa University is guided by the following core values:

Core Value	Description
Tolerance and Mutual Respect	The University promotes and maintains a culture that appreciates tolerance, mutual respect, and acknowledges the vital role of every member of the community
Social Responsibility	The University promotes good citizenship and active public engagement, and commits to partnership in extending knowledge and expertise for environmental protection and the betterment of all
Reliance on Evidence and Authority of Reason	All pronouncements and undertakings of the University shall be founded on reason and evidence
Student Centeredness	The University is committed to providing an academically challenging and supportive learning environment that motivates students to be actively engaged in their own learning, decision making, and governance
Developing Corruption-free Culture	The University promotes ethical conduct and fights corruption at individual, collective, and institutional levels and inculcates anti-corruption thinking and actions among the University community
Transparency and Accountability	The University is committed to ensure accountability at institutional, group, and individual levels in the effort to implement its functions
Serving the Society	The University is committed to serve the society by advancing knowledge, finding solutions for societal

problems, providing relevant and demand driven training and engaging in outreach services

1.5 A Brief History of the University

Modern higher education in Ethiopia began with the founding of the University College of Addis Ababa on March 20, 1950. Within the following decade, several colleges were opened, including the College of Agriculture at Alemaya, the College of Engineering, the Institute of Building Technology, the Gondar Public Health College, and the Theological College of the Holy Trinity.

In February 1961, a charter brought all these faculties and colleges together to form the Haile Sellassie I University (HSIU). At the inauguration ceremony of December 18, 1961, the former palace grounds (the Sidist Kilo Campus) became the Main Campus of the new University. The institution became Addis Ababa University in 1975.

2. University Structure and Organization

2.1 Academic Organization

The highest decision-making body of the University is the Board of Governors. Most academic decisions are made by the University Senate, which regularly meets at least three to four times during an academic year.

2.2 University Leadership

The chief executive officer of the University is the President, assisted by four Vice Presidents:

- Academic Vice President
- Vice President for Research & Technology Transfer

- Vice President for Administration & Student Services
- Vice President for Institutional Development and Community Services

2.3 College-Level Governance

At the college level, the decision-making body in all academic matters is the Academic Commission of each college. The academic commission meets under the chairmanship of the Dean of the college and consists of:

- Department Chairpersons
- School/Centre Heads
- Elected staff members
- Student representatives
- Other relevant members

At department/school/centre levels, chairpersons/heads and department staff members deliberate on academic matters in the respective department/school/centre academic and graduate committees.

2.4 Teaching Academic Units

The University includes the following teaching academic units:

College/Institute	Abbreviation
Addis Ababa Institute of Technology	AAiT
Ethiopian Institute of Architecture, Building Construction and City Development	EiABC
College of Business and Economics	CBE
College of Development Studies	CDS

College of Education and Behavioral Studies	CEBS
College of Health Sciences	CHS
College of Humanities, Language Studies, Journalism and Communication	CHLSJC
College of Law and Governance Studies	CLGS
College of Natural Sciences	CNS
Institute of Peace and Security Studies	IPSS
College of Performing and Visual Arts	CPVA
College of Social Sciences	CSS
College of Veterinary Medicine and Agriculture	CVMA

2.5 Research Institutes

The University also houses several research institutes:

- Institute of Ethiopian Studies (IES)
- Institute of Educational Research (IER)
- Aklilu Lemma Institute of Pathobiology (ALIP)
- Institute of Geophysics, Space Science and Astronomy (IGSSA)
- Ethiopian Institute of Water Resources (EIWR)

2.6 Campuses

The Main Campus at Sidist Kilo has a large complex of buildings used for administration and classrooms. The former main palace building now houses the Institute of Ethiopian Studies. There is a separate building for the offices of the president, vice presidents, and directors. The Main Registrar is housed in other buildings located in

Sidist Kilo Campus. The Kennedy Memorial Library and the Addis Ababa University Cultural Centre are also located in the Main Campus.

Many of the colleges/institutes have their own campuses in Addis Ababa, Bishoftu (DebreZeit), and Selale (Fiche).

3. Registration and Enrollment

3.1 Undergraduate Admission

Placements for all regular undergraduate programs are processed through the Ministry of Education. The university then conducts admission and enrollment to the different programs based on results of the Ethiopian Higher Education Entrance Examination and other relevant criteria.

3.2 Registration Process

Students must complete online registration to be assigned to a section. Failure to do so may result in difficulties in attending classes and course assessment entry by the instructors.

3.3 Class Assignment and Schedule

After registration, students must:

- Check their assigned section on the student portal
- Check their college noticeboard for class schedules
- Report to the correct campus and classroom as assigned

3.4 Campus Transfer and Clearance

Students assigned to a new campus must complete clearance forms and access new facilities through the college's student service office. Attending classes at the wrong campus without proper clearance may result in attendance not being recorded.

3.5 Registration by Program

Students must register at specific locations based on their program of study:

Program	Registration Location
Doctor of Medicine, Dental Medicine, Pharmacy, Other Health Sciences	College of Health Sciences @ Tikur Anbessa Campus
Pre-engineering (EIABC)	College of Technology and Built Environment @ Lideta Campus
Pre-engineering (AAiT)	College of Technology and Built Environment @ 5 Kilo Campus
Computer Science, Information Systems, Other Natural Sciences	College of Natural and Computational Sciences @ 4 Kilo Campus
Doctor of Veterinary Medicine, Veterinary Laboratory Technology	College of Veterinary Medicine and Agriculture @ Bishoftu Campus
Law	School of Law @ Main Campus
Other Social Sciences	College of Social Sciences, Arts and Humanities,

College of Education and Language Studies, College of Business and Economics @ 6 Kilo, Commerce Campus, and Performing and Visual Arts Campus

4. Academic Programs

4.1 Types of Academic Programs

Academic programs offered at AAU fall into three categories:

- First degree (BSc or BA)
- Second degree (MSc or MA)
- Third degree (PhD)

Specialty certificates are also given for those who have an MD and have served for a reasonable period of time. Specialty certificates are offered under the College of Health Sciences.

4.2 Undergraduate Programs by College

Addis Ababa Institute of Technology (AAiT):

- BSc in Biomedical Engineering (5 years)
- BSc in Chemical Engineering (5 years)
- BSc in Civil Engineering (5 years)
- BSc in Electrical and Computer Engineering (5 years)
- BSc in Information Technology (5 years)
- BSc in Mechanical Engineering (5 years)
- BSc in Software Engineering (5 years)

Ethiopian Institute of Architecture, Building Construction and City Development (EiABC):

- BSc in Architecture (5 years)
- BSc in Construction Technology and Management (5 years)
- BSc in Urban and Regional Planning (5 years)

College of Business and Economics (CBE):

- BA Degree in Accounting (3 years)
- BA in Administrative Services Management (3 years)
- BA Degree in Business Administration and Information System (3 years)
- BA Degree in Finance and Development Economics (3 years)

College of Social Sciences (CSS):

- BA in Archeology & Heritage Management (3 years)
- BA in Geography & Environmental studies (3 years)
- BA in History (3 years)
- BA in Philosophy (3 years)
- BA in Political Science and International Relations (3 years)
- BA in Social Work (3 years)
- BA in Sociology (3 years)
- BA in Social Anthropology (3 years)

College of Natural Sciences (CNS):

- BSc in Biotechnology (4 years)
- BSc in Chemistry (3 years)
- BSc in Geology (4 years)
- BSc in Information System (4 years)
- BSc in Mathematics (3 years)
- BSc in Physics (3 years)

- BSc in Sport Science (3 years)
- BSc in Statistics (3 years)
- BSc in Biology (3 years)

College of Performing and Visual Arts (CPVA):

- BFA degree in Art Education (5 years)
- BFA degree in Design (5 years)
- BFA degree in Painting (5 years)
- BFA degree in Print Making (5 years)
- BFA degree in Sculpture (5 years)
- BA in Theater Arts (4 years)
- BA in Music (Jazz Performance) (5 years)
- BA in Music (Music Education) (5 years)
- BA in Music (Performance) (5 years)

College of Veterinary Medicine and Agriculture (CVMA):

- Doctor of Veterinary Medicine (DVM) (6 years)
- BSc in Agricultural Economics (3 years)
- BSc in Animal Science & Technology (3 years)
- BSc in Horticulture (3 years)
- BSc in Plant Science (3 years)

5. Grading System

5.1 Grade Components

Students are evaluated through continuous assessments (quizzes, assignments, projects, laboratory work, and mid-semester examinations) and final examinations. The

specific weight of each component is determined by the respective college or department and communicated to students through course outlines at the beginning of each semester.

5.2 Grading Scale

The university uses a letter grading system with corresponding grade points:

Letter Grade	Grade Point	Performance Level
A	4.0	Excellent
B+	3.5	Very Good
B	3.0	Good
C+	2.5	Satisfactory
C	2.0	Acceptable
D	1.0	Marginal Pass
F	0.0	Fail

5.3 Grade Point Average (GPA)

The university uses two types of GPA calculations:

- **Semester Grade Point Average (SGPA):** The average of grades earned in a single semester
- **Cumulative Grade Point Average (CGPA):** The average of grades earned across all completed semesters

Both are calculated by dividing the total grade points earned by the total credit hours attempted.

5.4 NG (No Grade) Designation

Students who receive “NG” (No Grade) designations must follow this procedure:

- Appeal to the College Academic Affairs Office
- Have the case processed according to AAU Senate Legislation Articles 95.4 – 95.7 and 104
- After resolving the grade issue, the Vice Dean must request program placement from the Main Registrar's Office

6. Attendance Policy

6.1 General Requirements

Regular class attendance is mandatory for all registered students at Addis Ababa University. The university considers attendance integral to the learning process and a prerequisite for successful course completion.

6.2 Minimum Attendance Requirement

Students are expected to attend all scheduled lectures, tutorials, laboratory sessions, and practical classes. The specific attendance requirements may vary by course and college, but generally, students must maintain a minimum of 80% attendance to be eligible for final examinations.

6.3 Absence Due to Extracurricular Activities

The university recognizes that participation in approved extracurricular activities may require absence from class. However, participation in such activities is a privilege that carries additional expectations for acceptable conduct. Students participating in approved activities remain responsible for completing all course requirements.

6.4 Excessive Absences

Students who exceed the permitted number of absences may be:

- Required to withdraw from the course
- Denied permission to take the final examination
- Given a failing grade (F) in the course

6.5 Absence Due to Illness or Emergency

In cases of illness or family emergency, students must:

- Notify their instructor or department as soon as possible
- Provide appropriate documentation (medical certificate, police report, etc.)
- Make arrangements with instructors to complete missed work

7. Academic Integrity and Plagiarism Rules

7.1 Definition of Academic Integrity

Academic integrity is the foundation of the university's educational mission. Addis Ababa University defines academic integrity as the commitment to honest, ethical, and responsible scholarly conduct in all academic work. The university expects all students to adhere to the highest standards of academic honesty.

7.2 Definition of Plagiarism

Plagiarism is defined as “the unauthorized use or close imitation of the language and thoughts of another author and the representation of them as one's own original work.” This includes both intentional copying and unintentional failure to properly attribute sources.

7.3 Forms of Academic Dishonesty

The university recognizes several forms of academic dishonesty:

Type	Description
Direct Plagiarism	Word-for-word copying without quotation marks or citation
Mosaic Plagiarism	Patching together phrases from sources without proper attribution
Self-Plagiarism	Reusing one's own previously submitted work without permission
Cheating	Using unauthorized materials or assistance during examinations
Fabrication	Falsifying data, sources, or experimental results
Facilitating Academic Dishonesty	Helping another student commit an act of academic dishonesty

7.4 Consequences of Academic Dishonesty

The university has established graduated sanctions depending on the severity and intent of the violation:

- **For Undergraduate Students:** Course failure, academic probation, or suspension
- **For Graduate Students:** Thesis rejection, degree revocation, or expulsion
- **For Degree Holders:** Revocation of degrees already awarded in cases of significant falsification of data or plagiarism

The university explicitly reserves the right to revoke degrees in cases of significant falsification of data or plagiarism, even after graduation.

7.5 Detection Methods

The university employs several methods to detect plagiarism and academic dishonesty:

- Plagiarism detection software (such as Turnitin)
- Manual review by faculty members
- Cross-checking of theses and dissertations against unpublished reports and other student work
- Proctored examinations

8. Examinations and Assessments

8.1 Types of Examinations

AAU administers several types of examinations:

Exam Type	Purpose
Course Examinations	Assess performance in specific courses
Mid-Semester Examinations	Assess progress during the semester
Final Examinations	Assess comprehensive knowledge at semester end
Comprehensive/Qualifying Exams	Assess graduate student readiness for candidacy
Graduate Admission Test (GAT)	Screen applicants for graduate programs

Undergraduate Admission Test (UAT)	Assess candidates for undergraduate admission

8.2 Examination Regulations

Prohibited Items in Testing Rooms:

- Electronic devices (cell phones, smartphones, tablets, smart watches, laptops)
- Internet access devices
- Communication devices (headphones, earphones, Bluetooth devices)
- Books, notes, study materials, textbooks, handouts, scratch papers
- Unauthorized calculators
- Unauthorized aids (rulers, protractors, compasses, formula sheets)

Consequences: Students found with prohibited items may be removed from the examination hall, have their tests invalidated, and face additional disciplinary action.

8.3 Examination Day Procedures

Arrival Requirements:

- Students must arrive at least 30 minutes before the scheduled examination time
- Latecomers may not be permitted to enter the examination hall

Required Materials:

- Valid university identification card
- Printed admission ticket (if applicable)
- Writing materials as specified by the instructor

8.4 Missed Examinations

Students who fail to appear for scheduled examinations must:

- Provide valid documentation for their absence within one week
- Petition for a make-up examination through their college
- Pay any applicable fees

Make-up examinations are granted only for valid reasons such as serious illness, family emergency, or university-approved activities.

8.5 Examination Results

Examination results are typically posted within two to four weeks after the examination period. Students may access their grades through the student portal or at their college noticeboards.

9. Student Services

9.1 Registrar's Office

The Main Registrar's Office is located in the Sidist Kilo Campus. The Registrar's Office is responsible for:

- Student registration and enrollment
- Maintenance of academic records
- Issuance of transcripts and diplomas
- Verification of student status

Contact: registrar@aau.edu.et

9.2 Library Services

The Kennedy Memorial Library, located in the Main Campus, serves as the central library. Additionally, each college has its own branch library with collections specific to its disciplines. Library services include:

- Borrowing and return of materials
- Reference services
- Electronic databases and journals
- Study spaces
- Photocopying services

9.3 ICT Services

The university maintains computer centers with internet-connected computers for student use. ICT services include:

- Student portal access (portal.aau.edu.et)
- Email services
- Wireless internet (Wi-Fi) on campuses
- Computer laboratories
- E-learning platforms

Contact: ict@aau.edu.et | +251-111-223862

9.4 Student Affairs

The Vice President for Administration and Student Services oversees student affairs, including:

- Student housing and dining services
- Health services
- Counseling and guidance
- Extracurricular activities
- Student organizations and clubs

Contact: vpass@aau.edu.et | +251-111-239783

9.5 Health Services

The College of Health Sciences provides health services to students through the Tikur Anbessa Specialized Hospital and campus clinics. Services include:

- Primary health care
- Emergency services
- Health education and promotion
- HIV/AIDS prevention and control programs

Contact: health.sciences@aau.edu.et | +251-118-959055

9.6 Gender Office

The Gender Office promotes gender equality and addresses gender-based issues on campus:

- Provides support services for female students
- Addresses sexual harassment complaints
- Promotes women's participation in all university activities

Contact: gender@aau.edu.et | +251-111-233828

9.7 Career Development Services

The university provides career development services to help students prepare for their professional futures:

- Career counseling
- Job search assistance
- Internship placement
- Resume and interview workshops

Contact: Careerdevelopment@aau.edu.et

9.8 Financial Services

The Finance Office handles student financial matters, including:

- Tuition and fee payments
- Scholarship administration
- Financial aid disbursement

Contact: finance@aau.edu.et | +251-111-223686

10. Code of Conduct

10.1 General Principles

All students are expected to conduct themselves in a manner that reflects positively on the university community. This includes:

- Respecting the rights and dignity of others
- Maintaining academic integrity
- Complying with university policies and regulations
- Refraining from behavior that disrupts university activities
- Respecting university property

10.2 Student Rights

Students at Addis Ababa University have the right to:

- Quality education and fair assessment
- Access to university facilities and resources
- Freedom of expression and association within university guidelines
- Representation in university governance through student councils
- Fair treatment in all university processes
- Confidentiality of personal records

- Appeal academic and disciplinary decisions

10.3 Student Responsibilities

Every student bears the responsibility to:

- Familiarize themselves with and abide by university policies
- Attend classes regularly and participate actively in learning
- Complete assignments and examinations honestly
- Respect instructors, staff, and fellow students
- Use university property responsibly
- Maintain appropriate academic progress
- Pay all required fees on time
- Present valid identification when requested

10.4 Prohibited Conduct

The following behaviors are prohibited and may result in disciplinary action:

Academic Misconduct:

- Cheating on examinations or assignments
- Plagiarism
- Fabrication of data or sources
- Unauthorized collaboration
- Aiding others in academic dishonesty

Behavioral Misconduct:

- Physical assault or threats
- Harassment, intimidation, or bullying
- Discrimination based on gender, ethnicity, religion, or other protected characteristics

- Disruptive behavior in classes or university facilities
- Hazing or initiation activities
- Possession or use of alcohol or illegal drugs on campus
- Possession of weapons on campus
- Theft or vandalism of university property
- Unauthorized entry into university facilities

10.5 Disciplinary Procedures

When a violation is reported, the following general procedures apply:

- **Investigation:** The Dean of Students or appropriate office investigates the complaint
- **Notice:** The student is notified of the alleged violation and given an opportunity to respond
- **Hearing:** For serious matters, a disciplinary committee hearing may be convened
- **Decision:** Sanctions are determined based on the nature and severity of the violation
- **Appeal:** Students may appeal decisions through established channels

10.6 Possible Sanctions

Depending on the nature and severity of the violation, sanctions may include:

- Warning or reprimand
- Probation
- Restitution for damages
- Loss of privileges
- Grade penalties
- Course failure
- Suspension for a specified period

- Expulsion from the university
- Revocation of degree (for violations discovered after graduation)

10.7 Grievance Procedures

Students who believe they have been treated unfairly have the right to file a grievance:

- Attempt to resolve the matter informally with the involved party
- If unsuccessful, file a formal written grievance with the appropriate office (Department Chair, Dean of Students, or College Academic Affairs Office)
- The grievance will be reviewed and investigated
- A decision will be communicated in writing
- If dissatisfied, the student may appeal to the next level (College Academic Commission, University Senate)

11. Contact Information

11.1 Key University Offices

Office	Email	Phone
President Office	poffice@aau.edu.et	+251-111-239752
Academic Vice President	avp@aau.edu.et	+251-111-231088
V/P for Administration & Student Services	vpass@aau.edu.et	+251-111-239783
V/P for Research & Technology	vprtt@aau.edu.et	+251-111-

Transfer		239769
V/P for Institutional Development	vpid@aau.edu.et	+251-111-231084
Registrar	registrar@aau.edu.et	+251-111-239706
Finance Office	finance@aau.edu.et	+251-111-223686
ICT Office	ict@aau.edu.et	+251-111-223862
Communications Office	communications@aau.edu.et	+251-111-239705
Gender Office	gender@aau.edu.et	+251-111-233828

11.2 College Contacts

College	Email	Phone
College of Social Sciences	social.sciences@aau.edu.et	+251-111-239650
College of Business and Economics	business.economics@aau.edu.et	+251-111-229231
College of Natural Sciences	natural.sciences@aau.edu.et	+251-111-239472
College of Education and	behavioral.studies@aau.edu.et	+251-111-

Behavioral Studies		239780
College of Humanities, Language Studies, Journalism and Communication	humanities@aau.edu.et	+251-111-239721
College of Performing and Visual Arts	performing@aau.edu.et	+251-111-239713
College of Health Sciences	health.sciences@aau.edu.et	+251-118-959055
College of Veterinary Medicine and Agriculture	veterinary.medicine@aau.edu.et	+251-114-338450
College of Development Studies	development.studies@aau.edu.et	+251-114-349392
School of Social Work	socialwork@aau.edu.et	+251-111-225950

11.3 Other Important Contacts

Office	Email	Phone
Addis Ababa University Press	aau.press@aau.edu.et	+251-111-239746
Budget Office	budget@aau.edu.et	+251-111-239727
Procurement Office	Procurement@aau.edu.et	+251-111-225957

External Relations, Partnerships and Communications	external.relations@aau.edu.et	+251-111-239756

11.4 Official Online Portals

- **AAU Main Website:**http://www.aau.edu.et/
- **Student Portal:**https://portal.aau.edu.et/
- **Admission Portal:**https://admission.aau.edu.et/

12. Important Reminders

12.1 Policy Updates

Students are responsible for staying informed about policy updates through:

- The AAU student portal
- College notice boards
- Official university announcements
- Communication from the Registrar's Office

12.2 Deadlines

All university deadlines are strictly enforced. Students must adhere to published deadlines for:

- Registration
- Course add/drop
- Fee payment
- Grade appeals
- Graduation applications

12.3 Documentation

Students should maintain copies of all documents submitted to the university, including:

- Registration confirmations
- Fee payment receipts
- Admission tickets
- Official correspondence
- Grade reports

12.4 Compliance

Ignorance of policies is not an excuse for violations. Students are expected to familiarize themselves with and comply with all university policies and regulations.

12.5 Senate Legislation Supremacy

Where information in this handbook is in disagreement with the University Senate Legislation, the Legislation shall take precedence.

12.6 Questions and Clarifications

Students with questions about university policies should:

- Contact their College Registrar's Office
- Consult with the Dean of Students
- Refer to official university publications and websites
- Seek guidance from academic advisors